

MEANS OF INFORMATION

Learning Outcomes

After studying this chapter the students will be able to:

1. Identify the various means of information.
2. Differentiate between mass-media and non mass-media.
3. Identify the advantages and disadvantages of various means of information.
4. Identify the role of media in the political process.
5. Distinguish between relevant and irrelevant information.
6. Differentiate between different points of view on a subject in newspapers articles and news reports.
7. Identify bias in advertisements and news reports.
8. Interpret information from newspapers, television, and internet.
9. Make a class newspaper (informative articles, advertisements, editorials, news items, weather reports, cartoons, etc.).
10. Create a public service message on a current social or environmental issue for radio, television, newspaper or internet.
11. Conduct a survey with students in their school to identify the most and least popular TV program and share the information (organize information in the form of tables, graphs, and charts).
12. Defend their position on which is the most important means of information today.

COMMUNICATION

Communication is a process of sending messages to others and receiving messages from others. We send messages to others by speaking, writing or by making signs. In the past most of this communication was done by telephone or through writing letters and sending them by post. Nowadays, most communication takes place through mobile phones and the internet. We talk on mobile phones and Skype with people at home and around the world through the internet. We send SMS messages on mobile phones. We also use mobile phones and the internet to send letters by e-mail (electronic mail) to people anywhere in the world almost immediately. These means of communication are usually limited to communicating with a few people such as family, friends and colleagues at work.

THE MEANS OF INFORMATION

A means of communication that reaches a large number of people at the same time is called mass communication. Newspapers, the radio, television and the internet are the mass media used for mass communication. The mass media serves as a means of information as it keeps people informed of the events that are taking place within the country and around the world.

Newspapers

The older means of information is the newspaper. Newspapers cover local, national and world news. They also have informative articles, interesting stories and advertisements.

In Pakistan, daily newspapers are generally published in Urdu and English. Newspapers are also published in Sindhi, Punjabi, Gujarati, Pushto and Siraiki languages. Many newspapers publish special editions on Sunday and a special section for children once a week. Supplements on national days and special events are also taken out. The main source of income for newspapers comes from advertisements.



Nowadays most newspapers are published online in addition to print. The online versions of newspapers are called online newspapers or news sites.

Teachers Note:

Bring in 2-3 different newspapers and show the students the different sections: news, articles, editorial, weather reports and cartoons.

Activity

Make a class newspaper. In groups of four choose one section of the newspaper to prepare. For example, one group write articles on events that have occurred in your school, another group writes stories that will entertain and so on. When all groups have completed their work, put it together in the form of a newspaper. Place it in a place so other children in the school can read it. If you have access to the computer and the internet you can prepare an online newspaper.

Radio

The radio is an important means of information, education and entertainment. Radio stations broadcast the news and various educational and entertainment programs.



Guglielmo Marconi invented the radio in 1895AD. As the radio can be battery operated, it is easy to transport and can be listened to anywhere, even while on the move such as while driving a car.

At the time of independence, Pakistan had three radio stations which were established at Peshawar, Lahore and Dhaka. Now, almost every large city in the country has a radio station that broadcasts news and entertainment programmes in different languages. Radio stations earn money to produce and broadcast their programmes through advertisements.

Activity

Identify three merits and three demerits of the radio.

Television

Television is another important means of information. News programmes, documentaries and dramas on television inform, educate and entertain people. Special programmes are telecast to educate and entertain children. Nowadays with the latest satellite technology, events taking place within the country and abroad are telecast live.



The first television station of Pakistan was established in 1964, at Lahore and for a long time there was only one channel, that is, PTV. Nowadays, dish antennas and cable networks have increased our access to a large number of television channels. Many of these channels show programmes in one area such as news, sports or drama. These days you can watch television programmes through the internet as well.

Like the newspaper and radio, advertisements are the main source of money. Television owners or cable operators charge a small fee which provides income to them. Some of the income is used to produce or purchase the various programmes telecast.

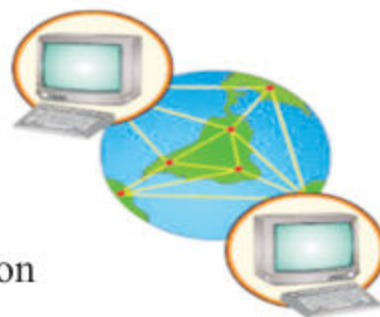
Activity

Identify three advantages and three disadvantages of television.

Internet

The information sharing system of millions of inter connected computers from around the world is called the Internet. The internet is a huge storehouse of information on all subjects. We can obtain information on any topic by simply typing in the keywords in the search engines.

Some people do fraud on internet by posting fake information or steal secrete information, called Hacking.

**Advertisements**

One of the major uses of mass media is advertising. Advertisements serve the purpose of drawing the attention of people to such things as products and services for sale, job vacancies and admissions in educational institutions. Advertisements are the main source of income for newspapers, radio stations, television channels and the Internet. Advertisements are usually biased because they only tell us the good things about the goods and services being sold. For example, eating lots of food cooked in oil is not good for our health but advertisements for cooking oil often state how good they are for our health. Similarly, soaps claim to make us fair and lovely when in reality all they do is help us to stay clean.

Activity

Look at advertisements in newspapers or on television and identify all the positive things about the product or service being advertised. Now write at least three things that are negative about the product or service.

Factors that Influence the Information We Receive

When news is spread by word of mouth, people tend to play up or play down an event, depending on the importance of the event to them. The same happens with newspaper, radio, television and the internet. There are numerous news article for publication, to be broadcast or shown on television. A news article should be a description of some factual situation and should not contain the reporters personal opinions. For example, when a reporter visits the site of an earthquake, he/she should report what actually happened in the affected area. However, in the news report experiences and observations of the affected people may be reported in a way that may be biased. For example, in a news report on an earthquake, the reporter may present the views of a small group of affectees who have not been properly assisted by the government, while failing to note the large number of people who have been assisted well.

We need to be aware that what is printed, broadcast, telecast or put on the internet may not be presented truthfully but present one point of view. Therefore, when reading the newspaper, listening to the radio, watching television or accessing information from the internet we should not jump to conclusions but find out more and to use our critical thinking skills to work out our own views and opinions.

Activity: Read a story about the same event in two different newspapers (two different radio stations or two different television channels). Compare them (give similarities and differences). Say why you think they are different.

The Role of Media in the Political Process

The media has become increasingly influential in the political process in recent years. In a democracy, the free flow of information, ideas, and opinions is critical. The media plays the role of providing people with correct and unbiased information about political persons, political events, political institutions and political processes so that they can act accordingly. It also facilitates the exchange of ideas and opinions on a wide range of topics of interest to the people. As everyone's ideas and opinions are different, the free exchange of ideas and opinions both supporting and opposing provides healthy debate and allows for people to make up their own mind regarding the ideas and views being discussed.

During elections the media keeps the people informed of who is standing for elections, the political party to which they belong, what role has the political party and the politicians played in the past and what the party aims to do for the welfare of the people if it comes to power. It, thus, facilitates communication between the candidates standing for elections and the voters.

Another very important role of the media is that it serves as a “watch dog” on all the three main branches of government: legislature, executive, and judicial branch. The press, radio and television call attention to wherever there is corruption, misuse and abuse of power in government with the proliferation of cable television and the internet. The media has become more active than ever in serving as a watch dog on the government. In the past decade, investigation journalism has exposed scores of crooked politicians, government officials and corporations.

SUMMARY

In this chapter we have learnt about the importance of communication that reaches a large number of people and the means such as newspapers, radio, television and the Internet that is used to facilitate mass communication. We have also learnt the importance of carefully considering what we read and hear as information can be biased by presenting only one point of view. This is especially so in advertisements. The importance of the mass media in our daily, especially the role it plays in the political process, that is, in helping us decide who to vote for and holding the government accountable is also discussed.

EXERCISE

A. Multiple choice questions

1. For every question, three answers are given; tick the correct one.

- i. The activity of sharing information with others is also called
 a. Communication b. Dialogue c. Discussion
- ii. Newspapers are a form of
 a. Electronic-Media b. Mass-Media c. Print-Media
- iii. Where was the first radio station of Pakistan established?
 a. Karachi b. Lahore c. Peshawar
- iv. When was the first TV station established in Pakistan?
 a. 1960 b. 1964 c. 1968
- v. What is the interconnection of computers around the world called?
 a. Letters b. Internet c. Telephone

B. Answer the following questions

1. List the various means of information.
2. What is the importance of the means of information?
3. Differentiate between mass-media and non mass-media.
4. What is the purpose of advertisements?
5. What is the role of the media in the political process?
6. Which is the most important means of information today? Give three reasons in support of your answer.

C. Make a table

Make a table like the one below. List the means of information. State two advantages and two disadvantage of each.

Means of Information	Advantages	Disadvantages

D. Practical work

1. Choose an advertisement. Look at it and answer the following questions.

- What is the name of the product being advertised?
- Describe the advertisement. (eg. Are they any people, how old are they, how are they dressed, is there anything written, what does it say).
- Who is it that the advertisers want to sell their product to? (eg. young people like you, your parents, wealthy people, girls, boys).
- How was the advertisement made appealing to the people the advertisers want to sell their product to? (eg. Use famous actor/actress, an expert such as a doctor/dentist, showed a lot of people using it)

- Is both positive and negative information about the product given?
- Do you think what the advertisers say about their product is true? Why?
- What information would the advertisers need to add to make it true?

Note: When there is only positive or only negative information provided about someone or something we say that it is biased.

2. Read two newspaper articles or watch the news on the television and identify the point of view presented therein.
3. Read a news article about the same event in an Urdu and English newspaper. Identify the point of view presented in each.
4. Working together in small groups create a public service message on the issue of environmental pollution to be communicated through radio, television or the Internet. Share your message with your colleagues in class as you would on radio, television or the Internet with your class.
5. Prepare a questionnaire to find out which is the most popular television program and which is the least popular television program in your school. Conduct the survey. Organize the data collected and present in the form of a table or a graph.

E. Extension activities

1. Divide the class into 8 groups. Ask half the groups to design an advertisement to describe a product positively and encourage people to eat, visit, do or buy it. Ask the other half of the groups to describe it negatively and discourage people from eating, visiting, doing or buying it. Groups 1 and 2 Eating Burgers.
Groups 3 and 4 Visiting the Zoo
Groups 5 and 6 Cleaning the school as good citizens
Groups 6 and 7 Soap
Have the two groups come together and make an advertisement that is fair, that is, shows both the positive and negative sides of the good or service.
2. Visit a nearby radio or television station to see how it operates.

Teachers Note

Arrange a debate in class on "Television is the most important means of information". Have half the class be for the topic and half against the topic. Ask 3 students to share their ideas for the topic and 3 students to share their ideas against the topic. Encourage all the students to listen and to challenge the ideas presented.